excellent sense of timing. As WWII drew to a close and Jinnah's demand for Pakistan began to take shape in the form of nationwide communal conflagrations, Abdullah decided to test the waters by rocking the Maharaja's throne. In March 1946, Beg resigned from his ministerial post. At that time, the British Cabinet Mission was in India negotiating with Jinnah and the Congress party about the mechanics for the transfer of power. In May 1946, the National Conference launched the Quit Kashmir campaign against the Maharaja. In incendiary speeches, Abdullah condemned the sale of the valley by the British to Gulab Singh, in 1846.[21] He emphatically declared that this was an invalid act. It, therefore, followed that the Maharaja, as the descendant of the Dogra dynasty, was also an invalid ruler. He insisted that the Maharaja should leave Kashmir immediately and hand over power to the people of the state. It had taken 15 years of British Machiavellian intrigue to unleash the forces that had shaken the seemingly unshakeable rule of Gulab Singh's descendants.

The Poonch Imbroglio

Around the same time, in 1946, trouble was brewing in Poonch, which was a feudatory territory of Jammu and Kashmir. Way back in 1827, Maharaja Ranjit Singh had appointed Raja Dhyan Singh, Gulab Singh's brother, as the Raja of Poonch. Gulab Singh had been appointed as the Raja of Jammu. After the death of Maharaja Ranjit Singh in 1839, Dhyan Singh was assassinated in the September 1843 *coup d'état* against the Sikh Emperor Sher Singh, in Lahore. It is speculated that Gulab Singh had a role to play in this event. Thereafter, Poonch was confiscated by the Sikh Empire on the grounds of Raja Dhyan Singh's rebellion. Poonch was handed over to Faiz Talib Khan of Rajouri and after the signing of the Treaty of Amritsar, it was transferred to Maharaja Gulab Singh by the British. He, in turn, restored Poonch to Jawahir Singh, the eldest surviving son of Dhyan Singh, albeit with the reduced status of a *jagir,* a feudal land grant.

Gulab Singh had cleverly managed to neutralise the potential opposition he and his descendants would have faced from his family. The rumoured